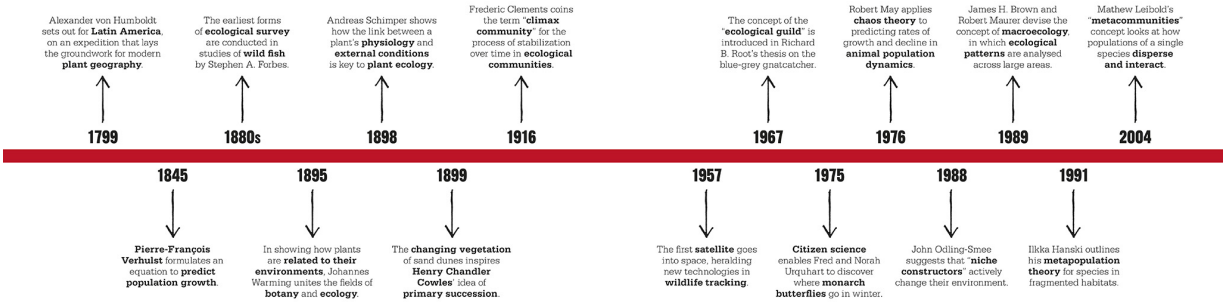
INTRODUCTION

The distribution of organisms through space and time is a fundamental interest of ecology. Early in the 19th century, Prussian explorer Alexander von Humboldt, a founding father of ecology, made detailed studies of plant geography in Latin America. Philip Sclater described the global distribution of bird species, and Alfred Russel Wallace did the same for other vertebrates, proposing six zoogeographic regions that are largely still in use today.



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Communities

Early fieldwork concentrated on the distribution and abundance of organisms, but later in the 19th century scientists increasingly recognized that survey data could also throw light on interactions between species. In a sense, this represented the true birth of the field of ecology. Pioneers included American naturalist Stephen A. Forbes, who studied wild fish populations in the 1880s, and Danish botanist Johannes Warming, who examined the interaction between plants and their environment and introduced the idea of plant communities.

The link between climate and a region’s dominant vegetation type was set out by German botanist Andreas Schimper, who produced a worldwide classification of vegetation zones in 1898. In the early years of the 20th